

Introduction

The famous biologist, Ernst Mayr, once had a debate with the legendary physicist, Carl Sagan, about why humans have not discovered life in outer space. After all, there are likely trillions of other planets. How could it be that we haven't encountered other living beings?¹

Of course, to communicate with extraterrestrial life, we need to be able to send signals to each other that can be perceived and understood. This, in turn, requires what we call "higher intelligence." Mayr, a towering figure in biology central to the biological species concept, argued that "lower intelligence" life forms, such as bacteria, survive for long periods and proliferate. Species with "higher intelligence" are smaller in number and seem to die off faster. Just one—*Homo sapiens*—has the ability to communicate with life on other stars. Perhaps "higher intelligence" is a "lethal mutation," as Noam Chomsky put it, reflecting on the debate.²

With the environmental crisis heating up, humanity needs to decide quickly whether it's better to be smart or stupid. Right now, it looks like we are choosing to be stupid. If we don't drive ourselves to extinction, we're on the fast track to a permanent nightmare.

For starters, we are overheating the planet, which is now 1.2°C above the pre-industrial level, and growing. Studies show that global heating has already produced more numerous and intense extreme weather events—hurricanes, monsoons, floods, wildfires, and droughts—because of anthropogenic (human-caused) climate change. If we keep pushing the global temperature up, we will trigger irreversible *tipping points*—catastrophic events, like the melting of the glacial ice sheets, the mass die-off of coral reefs, and the conversion of the Amazon rainforest into a savanna. These events cannot be undone once they're set in motion. Like falling dominoes, tipping points set off cascading effects that spiral out of control. Some environmental scientists believe that we've already triggered several tipping points. Even if that's true, it's absolutely essential to keep from triggering more.

In addition to overheating the planet, we are destroying the biodiversity and habitats that sustain the web of life. Humans are killing off species at